

Starting in childhood, whenever something bad happened, Schaefer said her parents would buy her a Pound Puppy (a stuffed animal from the drugstore). She made a “dangerous connection” between spending money and improving your mood. “We’d just started joking that any gift for when you felt bad about anything was just called a Pound Puppy,” she said.

“Pound Puppy” is a familiar mollifier, if not a familiar name for it. I’m sure many people in line at a Sephora or Foot Locker right now would tell you the same thing. Buying yourself a little present quiets the sad, even if you don’t have a diagnosed mental illness. Spending gets you high. But we can’t live our lives surrounded by Pound Puppies. We have to eventually address the barking.



TAKEAWAYS

- Seek out a doctor, a therapist, a support group, a therapy app, an Internet forum, or any other professionals and other people you can talk to specifically about money and your mental health. If you don’t know how to find these resources, use the Internet, or ask your primary care physician for recommendations.
- Recruit family and friends to act as your checks and balances. Julie Fast said she has a nephew who will say, “Auntie, you’re talking really fast.” Her mother can tell she’s manic when she texts her late at night. Friends have said, “You’re being annoying.” The rule is that she can’t get mad. She has to take it as a sign she needs help.
- Avoid people who feed your illness. “Friends” who force you to stay out late, drink, or give you a hard time for taking care of your mental health are not your friends.
- Social media can be helpful if used responsibly. If Fast posts on Facebook about how she’s feeling (either up or down), she said it’s great when people respond with uplifting thoughts or slow-down warnings. But